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different story to tell. According to Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal, Punjab is emerging as a major knowledge hub. "We have hired thousands of teachers in our term. Thirteen new colleges are going to be set up soon and they will cater chiefly to the neglected areas," he says. The state has signed pacts with leading corporates to set up an Indian School of Business in Mohali. A Central university in Bathinda and a world-class university in Amritsar are on the anvil. The Government has also earmarked 500 acres of land in the scenic surroundings of the Sutlej river for the Indian Institute of Technology in Ropar. Says Education Minister Upinderjeet Kaur: "We are taking rapid strides. By March, we would have recruited 32,000 teachers. We have also rationalised postings so that remote areas are not

left out. Punjab is the best in the country in terms of education standards and infrastructure."

Some findings, however, beg to disagree. Punjab's performance in the education sector has dipped since 2007 in terms of infrastructure and teacher attendance, according to the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) for the year 2009 facilitated by Pratham, an NGO. In 2009, only 40 per cent of schools in Punjab had perfect teacher attendance compared to 46 per cent in 2007. Even infrastructure facilities have taken a beating with only 87 per cent schools having the facility of potable water.

"The pressures and demands in the education sector have increased immensely over the past decades and sadly the budget proportion on education has declined," says Punjabi University's economics head Ranjit Singh Ghuman. "With government institutions facing a scarcity of teachers and facilities, it has led to the

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PARKASH SINGH BADAL, *Chief Minister, Punjab*



areas," says state director-general, school education, Krishan Kumar.

However, it would be unfair to blame the present regime alone for the crisis. After all, education has been a major sufferer since the 1980s when terrorism rocked the state. Besides, Punjab has been in the grip of a financial crisis from which there appears to be no signs of recovery. Thus, the education budget has been declining constantly. During 1978-81, Punjab diverted 23.82 per cent of the state's total budget to education which came down to 10.72 per cent during 2004-07. Perhaps leaving it all on fees to fund it, Punjab presently allocates a pittance—over 2 per cent of its revenue to the sector. This is less than Bihar and Rajasthan which have far less per capita income.

But the state Government has a

The Education Jam

- Out of a total of 1,573 sanctioned posts for school principals across the state, 1,175 have been vacant for nearly a decade now.
- About 30,000 vacancies of teachers in schools are yet to be filled.
- Punjab currently allocates a pittance—just over 2 per cent of its revenue—to education.
- A couple of years ago, the Farmers' Commission pointed out that 69 per cent of rural households in Punjab did not have a single member who had completed Class X.

mushrooming of private institutions which have only made education costlier. As a result, a sizeable population of the state cannot afford education," he adds. Ghuman's point is not off the mark. There are studies that point to the worsening education scenario in the state. "Only about 4 per cent of those who passed matriculation reach universities and professional colleges. The education system in the state has become dysfunctional, thanks to a large number of vacancies and lack of monitoring by the Government," says Dr Jaswinder Brar, a reader in the same department who did a recent study on rural students.

With the state Government burdened by its never-ending debts, the fact that education is a debt the present generation owe to the future must never be forgotten. ■